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STRIPES

THE UNCOMMON VOICE: Adiga

tales had come to us unclothed, without the charming, quixotic ethnographic frames that he creates for each.

Between the Assassinations is indeed exquisitely packaged, a collection of raw, angry, hungry tales that are told with simplicity and a sure-footed irony that belies Adiga's freshness in the field, made "real" by the chronicling of topographical and climatic minutiae—streets and buildings, parks and landmarks, summer scorches and monsoon drenchers—along with historical trivia, and given further credence by the delineation of days and dates. An engrossing raconteur of everyday small-town India, Adiga has

and its low-key tourist attractions. The stories are then spread through from Day One to Day Seven, mornings, afternoons and evenings, measuring out lives in coffee spoons, stopping at houses identified by Kittur's local church, school, market, temple, mosque, and meeting its diverse and intriguing inhabitants, since a place derives its colour from its people: Ramakrishna, a.k.a. Xerox, who is arrested for selling pirated copies of *The Satanic Verses*; Mr D'Mello and his favourite student Girish at the Alfonso School; Shankara and his classmates who are suspected for planting a crude bomb in their chemistry class; Gururaj, the journalist, who made the mistake of wanting to find, and convey "the truth"

EXCERPT

Nightlife in Kittur is centred on Angel Talkies. Every Thursday morning, the walls of Kittur are plastered with hand-painted posters featuring a sketch of a hefty woman brushing her hair with her fingers; below, is the title of the movie: HER NIGHTS, WINE AND WOMEN, MYSTERIES OF GROWTH, UNCLE'S FAULT. The words 'Malayalam Colour' and 'Adults Only' are prominently featured on the posters. By 8 a.m., a long line of unemployed men has queued outside Angel Talkies, waiting for the first glimpse of the new screening. Show times are 10 a.m., noon, 2 p.m., 4 p.m. and 7 p.m. Seat prices range from Rs 2.20 for a seat up the

front to Rs 4.50 for a 'family seat' up in the balcony. Not far from the theatre is The Hotel Woodside, whose attractions include a famous Paris cabaret, featuring Ms Zeena from Bombay, every Friday, and Ms Ayesha and Ms Zimboo from Bahrain, every second Sunday. A travelling sexologist, Dr Kuruvilla, MBBS, MD, Mch, MS, DDBS, PCDB, visits the hotel the first Monday of every month. Less expensive and seedier in appearance than the Woodside are a nearby series of bars, restaurants, hostels, and apartments. Thanks to the presence of a YMCA in the neighbourhood, however, men of decency have the option of a moral and clean hostel.

set his protagonists down in Kittur to pursue their petty lives and dreams in a demarcated time-frame, the seven years between the two Gandhi killings that rocked our recent subcontinental history—Indira's in 1984 and Rajiv's in 1991—even as the country continues to reel and recover sporadically from the proliferating threat of political murders and mayhem, economic spirals both rising and plunging, and a social, cultural and religious ferment that goes hand-in-malicious-hand with grand narratives of India surging, soaring and shining.

Adiga innovatively sets up his narrative like a *Lonely Planet* guide, advising his readers that a week's visit to Kittur in the winter would be best, given its weather, its natural beauty

in his newspaper; Soumya and Raju, child-beggars just off Rose Lane; George D'Souza, the mosquito-man who accomplished himself at every odd job in the book for his elegant employer Mrs Gomes; Ratnakara Shetty, a pretend-sexologist who sold sugar pills as cure for venereal diseases at a street corner. He traverses classes and occupations, and the little town of Kittur transforms into a map of *aam admi* India—vocal, active, real.

There is less preachiness here than in *The White Tiger*, but also, less humour. If *Tiger* was intended to make us hang our heads in shame a la Naipaul's diatribes against the same area of Darkness, *Assassinations* reveals a writer in a more arresting, ambiguous relationship with its shadows. ■

allege, either, that Adiga is derivative; all writers who read voraciously do imbibe, selectively through a subconscious intellectual osmosis, tricks of the narrative trade that may fit like a snug glove the stories they want to tell. What strikes one early as *Assassinations* unfolds, perhaps also because Adiga's obvious literary training rings a personal chime, is how well-scaffolded and unerringly-structured his short stories are, and how much would have been lost if his Kittur